

percent will pay. So why put up the walled garden in the first place? Why spend money to ensure a walled garden when it has no effect on the outcome? It's all about control. And influencing your controlled user base to make more money. It's this very fact of hiding these intentions behind the guise of altruism that makes Facebook what it is, a for-profit corporate entity which eyes each new user as a source of revenue and nothing else.

CONCLUSION

Around the world, the concept of Net Neutrality is far from being reality as you'll soon find out. A few decades back, the concept of independence was the same. Someone has to fight the good fight, even if it ends up being a thankless job. The world has India to thank for the concept of Satyagraha, maybe it's time we added Net Neutrality to that list even if decades later people might take Net Neutrality for

granted the same way we take our independence for granted.

We don't doubt Mark Zuckerberg's genuine intentions of uplifting the poor but the way Facebook is going about the same is plain wrong. In a parallel universe, it might very well be that Facebook is trying to do the right thing and it is actually the Telcos that are being evil. We can never know for sure. After all, the road to hell is paved with good intentions. 



Facebook is NOT going to kill the internet

BY SIDDHARTH PARWATAY

It's easy to pander to popular opinion and cast a few stones in the right direction, in order to bag a few kudos along the way. The road less travelled – or in this case, taking an unpopular stance – is also more difficult. However, it's what we do here at Digit: analyse an issue by looking at it from all possible angles, even if the end result of the analysis goes against the popular opinion. At the very least, we are open to the existence of an alternate viewpoint. After all, even hardened criminals deserve representation and even if it's an unsavoury job someone's got to do it. Due process is logical, in line with the scientific bent of mind that we keep preaching. Plus, it's only fair.

A lot (and I mean an awful lot) has been written about why Free Basics is the harbinger of the internet apocalypse. Heck the previous few pages in this very magazine say exactly that! Now you have a few

more points to add to your next anti-Zuckerberg rant, which ironically enough, would take place on – surprise surprise – Facebook!

The whole argument for why Free Basics is not so bad hinges on whether some internet is better than no internet. On the surface at least you have to admit the notion isn't totally unfounded, especially when you know that not even 30 percent of the population in our country is connected. No one (and not even us, mind you) is saying that Free Basics is going to radically transform the lives of the underprivileged sections. But there has to be at least some benefit to be derived from gaining access to things like pregnancy and childcare information, job info, weather updates, free classifieds and Wikipedia in local languages – stuff that is universally regarded as beneficial.

There is an often quoted 2010 World Bank and IFC report which says for

every 10 percentage-point increase in high-speed Internet connections there is an increase in economic growth of 1.3 percentage points (<http://dgit.in/frbsc1>). “But that's high speed and unrestricted internet,” you scream! Yes, but you'll be surprised to know that even adding scaled down internet connections can increase time spent online by as much as 150 per cent. This was documented by Philippines telecom operator Smart Communications back in 2012 (<http://dgit.in/frbsc22>). If you follow that shortlink you'll also find that Google's own zero rated service Free Zone launched in the Philippines in collaboration with local carrier Globe Telecom, was aimed at enticing users to sign up for Internet services – an outcome that isn't horrible when applied to our Indian scenario. At the very least, such statistics prove the usefulness of basic internet access.